





PAPER TOWNS





CURATOR'S WELCOME



Welcome to TEDxPSU, and we are so excited to have you joining us today for our 15th annual conference. As we mark this milestone, we reflect on the incredible journey we've taken, the vibrant community we've built, and add eight new speakers to the TEDxPSU legacy. Whether it's groundbreaking research or personal stories of resilience and creativity, each talk is designed to provoke thought and spark conversations. And beyond the impact on those of us here in Happy Valley, we hope each speaker's idea creates change in the world around us.

Our team, consisting entirely of student volunteers, worked incredibly hard over the past year to put this event together. I would like to thank them for their efforts, ideas, and endless enthusiasm over the past year, as we couldn't have done this without them.

**Thank you for joining us, and welcome to
TEDxPSU 2025: Paper Towns.**

OLIVIA LECHTHALER
President & Curator



ABOUT TED

TED began in 1984 as a conference where Technology, Entertainment and Design converged, but today it spans a multitude of worldwide communities and initiatives exploring everything from science and business to education, arts and global issues. For their 40th anniversary in 2024, TED has changed their tagline from the famous “Ideas Worth Spreading” to “Ideas Change Everything.”

ABOUT TEDx

x=INDEPENDENTLY ORGANIZED EVENT

In the spirit of discovering and spreading ideas, TED has created a program called TEDx. TEDx is a program of local, self-organized events that bring people together to share a TED-like experience. Our event is called TEDx-PSU, where x = independently organized TED event. At our TEDxPSU event, TED Talks video and live speakers will combine to spark deep discussion and community connection. The TED Conference provides general guidance for the TEDx program, but individual TEDx events, including ours, are self-organized.

ABOUT TEDxPSU

TEDxPSU is The Pennsylvania State University's locally organized, student-run, yearly TEDx conference. Since our first conference in 2010, we have provided the Penn State and State College communities with a memorable and interactive day of events. We bring together innovative and thought-provoking individuals to share and showcase the best ideas from our community, and because we believe that ideas change everything, TEDxPSU is committed to providing the platform that allows these ideas to spread.



2010

**ATTEND.
LISTEN.
ENLIGHTEN.**

2012

**THE FULL
SPECTRUM**

2011

**RELICS TO
REVOLUTIONS**

2013

**YESTERDAY'S
FRONTIERS
TOMORROW'S
HORIZONS**

2015

**PUSH TO
START**

2014

GO FURTHER

2016

**DRIVE YOUR
REALITY**

2017

BREACH

2018

**FACE
TO FACE**

2019

CIRCUITRY

2020

CONTINUUM

15

YEARS OF TEDxPSU

2022
ENDEAVOR

2024
**ON THE
HORIZON**

2021
**TIME
TO PAUSE**

2023
**BLURRING
THE LINES**



2025
**PAPER
TOWNS**

PAPER TOWNS

Paper crinkles. A compass scratches against its surface, and a name is written. Years later, a town is formed.

In the early 20th century, cartographers and map makers would place fake towns, known as phantom settlements or paper towns, on their maps to protect their copyright. When cartographers Otto G. Lindberg and Ernest Alpers placed the fictitious town Agloe on a map to protect their copyright, they had no idea it would inspire a settlement of the same name years later.

These “paper towns” speak to the idea that small human actions lead to material change in the world. Few actions have outcomes as unknown but direct as the creation of Agloe, especially in our increasingly complex world. And yet, we hope our actions will have incredible impacts anyways.

At TEDxPSU 2025: Paper Towns, the 15th anniversary of the TEDx conference at Penn State, we invite you to find your own, small yet great, mark on a map as you hear ideas from eight speakers that once started as their own Paper Town.

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ITINERARY

OPENING REMARKS

SESSION 1

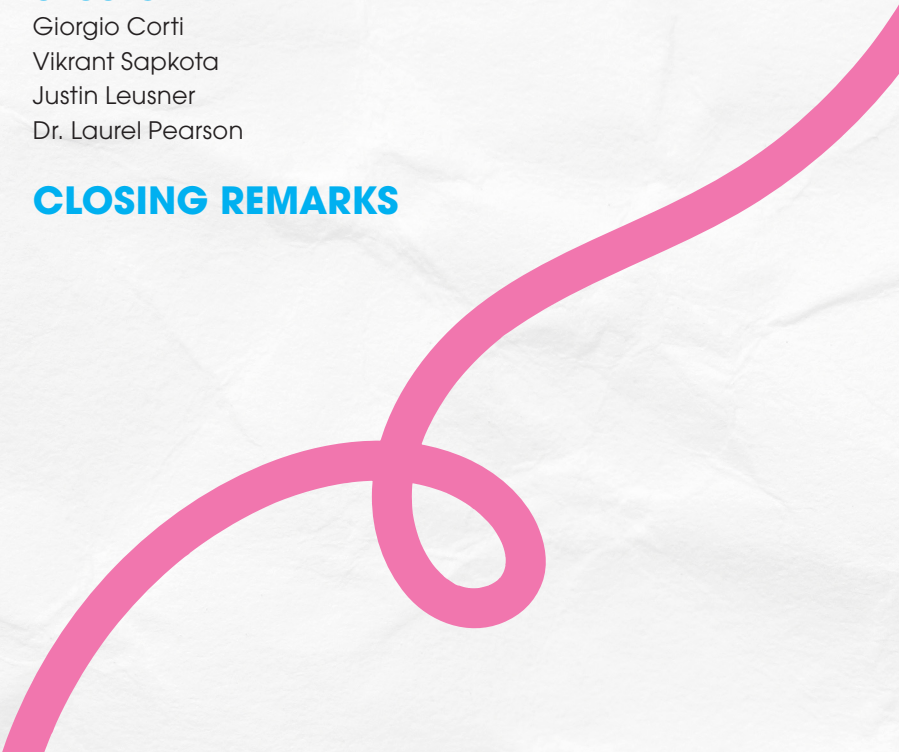
Jeffrey Edmunds
Rian Griffin
Dr. Michael McShane
Dima Abu-Aridah

INTERMISSION - 15 MINUTES

SESSION 2

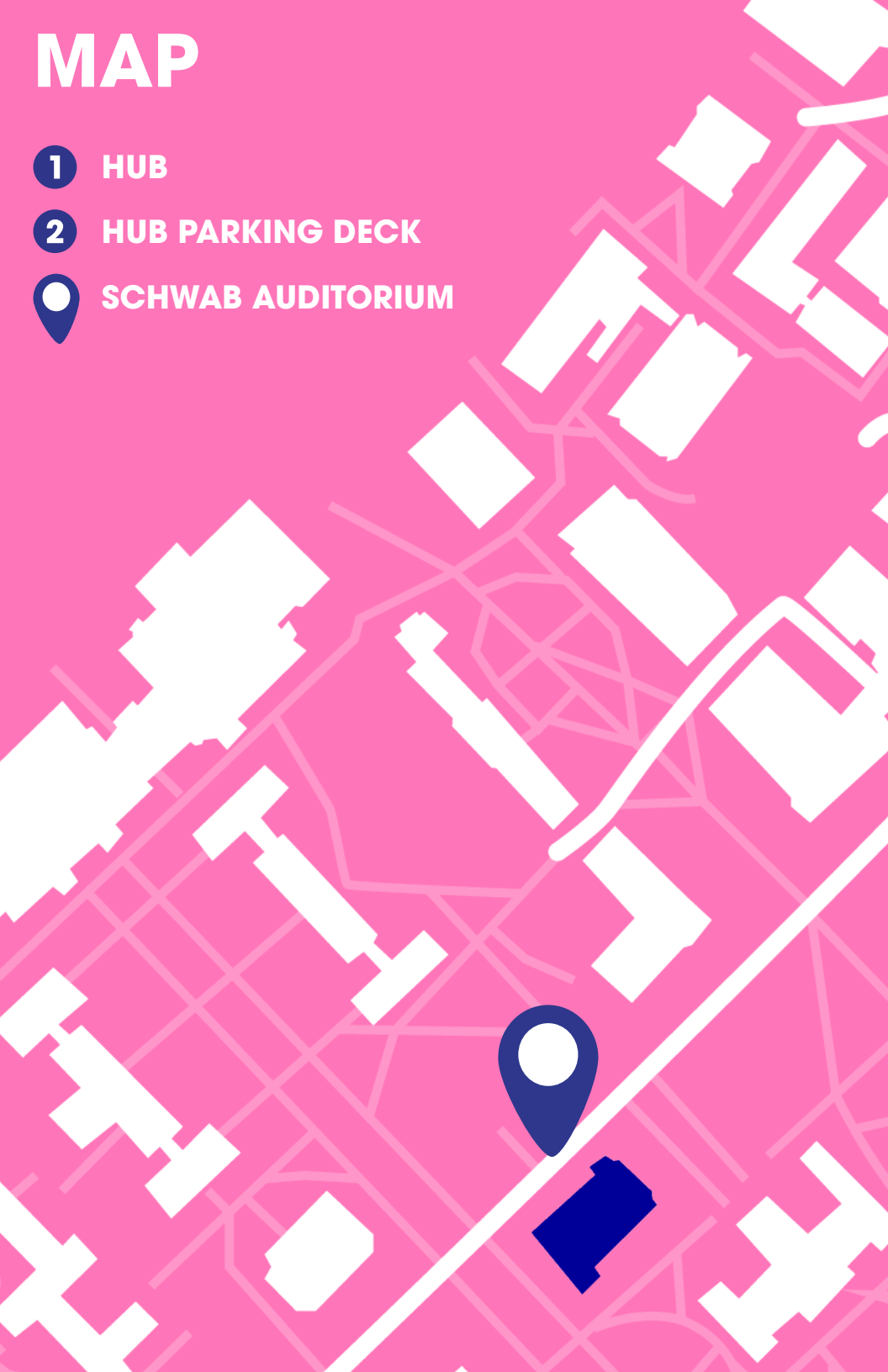
Giorgio Corti
Vikrant Sapkota
Justin Leusner
Dr. Laurel Pearson

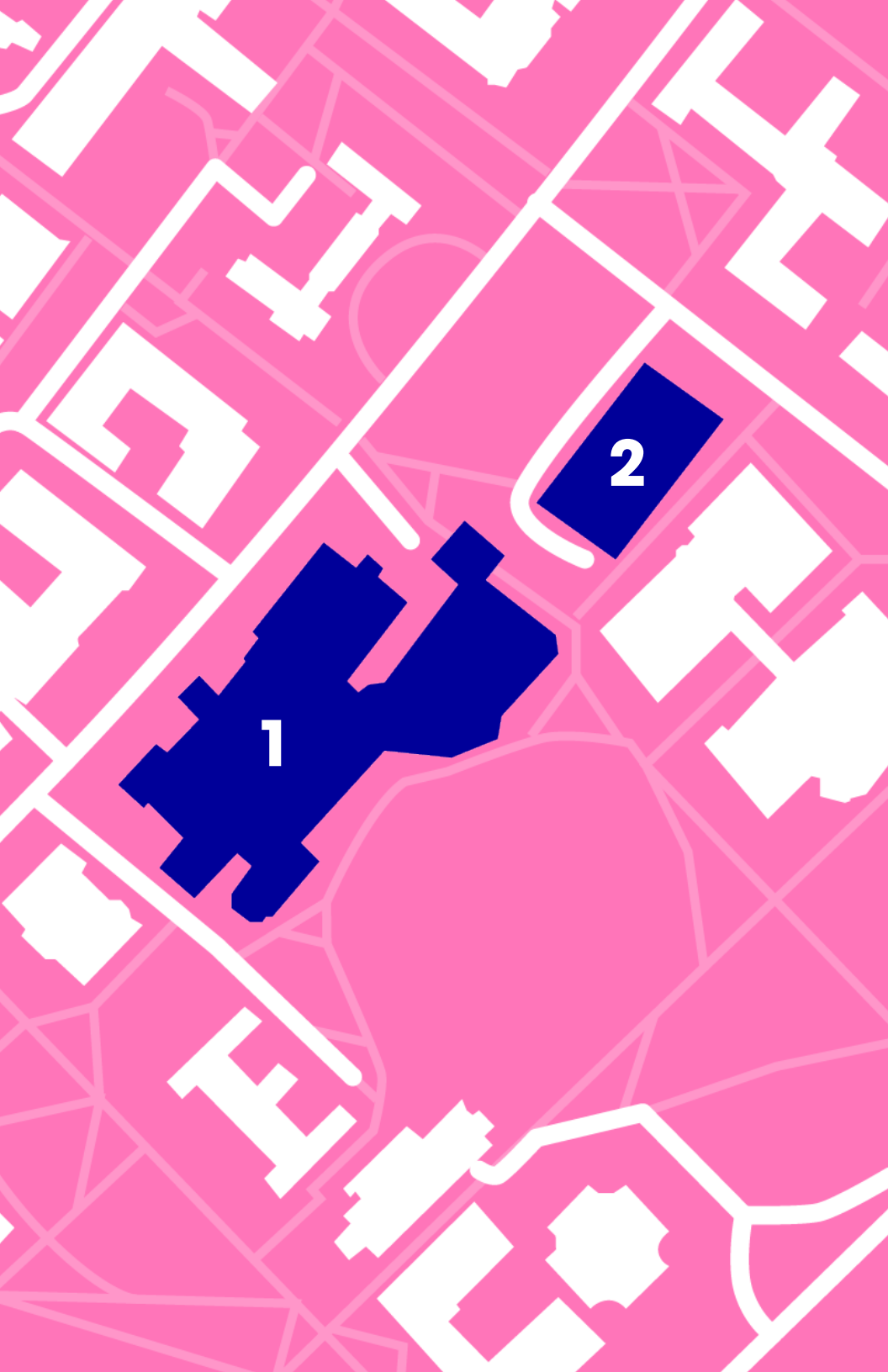
CLOSING REMARKS

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MAP

- 1 HUB
- 2 HUB PARKING DECK
-  SCHWAB AUDITORIUM





1

2



1 **SESSION**

JEFFREY EDMUNDS

Jeffrey Edmunds is Digital Access Coordinator at the Penn State University Libraries, where he has worked for more than 35 years. He helps manage access to the Libraries' millions of digital resources, especially eBooks, and is a fierce champion of open access to information. His texts have appeared in Nabokov Studies, The Slavic and East European Journal, McSweeney's, and Formules (Paris, France), among others. Jeffrey has decades of experience managing electronic resources in the context of a large academic research library which he now applies in lectures regarding e-books and their privatization.



RIAN GRIFFIN

Rian Griffin, a senior at Penn State studying civil engineering, is originally from Pittsburgh, PA. Upon graduation, Rian will join Kiewit, a construction company, where he'll be involved in a variety of projects from maintaining bridges in New York to developing tunnel systems in Baltimore. His passion for civil engineering stems from its practicality. He appreciates how civil engineers positively impact everyday life, from the water we drink to the roofs we sleep under. He enjoys city biking and kayaking in his free time and is also a Young Life Leader at Penn State, where he works to transform how students in the State College area perceive community.



DR. MICHAEL MCSHANE

Dr. Michael McShane is an Assistant Professor of Medicine at the Penn State College of Medicine. He is a clinician-educator that is passionate about improving the health and well-being of under-served communities. Dr. McShane is interested in the intersections of education, health systems, and sustainability. His research focuses on patient and community advocacy, ensuring their voices are heard when designing health solutions. He leads the LION Mobile Clinic, a student supported mobile effort to improve the health and well-being of the community.



DIMA ABU-ARIDAH

Dima Abu-Aridah is a Jordanian architect and a doctoral candidate at Penn State's Stuckeman School of Architecture. Recognized for her research on the design and spatial dynamics of refugee camps, Dima's work focuses on how displaced individuals reshape their environments to foster a sense of community and belonging. Her PhD dissertation, "Who Designs the Camp? The Spatial Reproduction of Refugee Camps," explores the interplay between spatial planning of camp spaces and the human ingenuity of refugees in adapting these spaces. Dima has been honored with Penn State's Graduate School's Alumni Association Dissertation Award in 2023 and the Graduate Student International Research Award in 2024 for her innovative contributions to understanding the intersection of design and displacement.





INTERMISSION



2

SESSION

GIORGIO CORTI

Giorgio Corti grew up in a small town close to Lake Como, Italy and moved alone to the United States in 2020 for an exchange program with his high school. He graduated in 2021 from Hopkinton High School in Massachusetts and decided to attend Penn State in August 2021. He is majoring in Management B.S. with a concentration in Finance and is a member of the Schreyer Honors College, where he is currently working on his final thesis. He will be graduating in the Spring of 2025. During the summer of 2024, he lived in New York City working at an investment banking internship at Barclays. After graduation he would like to continue working in the investment banking industry but plans on first pursuing an MBA.



VIKRANT SAPKOTA

Vikrant Sapkota is a dual-title PhD candidate in Climate Science and Meteorology at Penn State University, specializing in leveraging observational datasets and climate models to understand uncertainties in future climate change projections. He serves as the Vice President of the Science Policy Society at Penn State and represented the university as the graduate student delegate at COP28, the 2023 UN Climate Change Conference in Dubai. Vikrant has also worked as a Graduate High-Performance Computing Consultant, where he assisted departments across Penn State with their software and programming needs. He was awarded the Graduate Research Innovation Award from the Joint Fire Science Program and the Best Poster Award at the 2024 National Science Policy Symposium. He is deeply interested in the intersection of climate, public policy, and technology, with a focus on exploring innovative solutions like sunlight reflection methods to address climate change.



JUSTIN LEUSNER

Justin Leusner is a 22-year-old entrepreneur, storyteller, and follower of Jesus dedicated to addressing the Gen-Z mental health crisis through redemptive sports storytelling. As the visionary behind TDAY Sports, he leads a team of 30 creating Gen-Z-focused sports content that reaches hundreds of millions of fans monthly, earning 750 million views in just two years. Justin's work uses the power of sports to share stories of resilience, hope, and purpose, inspiring a generation to find meaning beyond the digital chaos. A sought-after speaker, he has shared his insights at events like CreatorFest, UCLA Discovery Conference, and Youth Marketing Strategy in London and NYC. Featured on ABC, FOX, and CBS, Justin's unique ability to connect, uplift, and motivate makes him a powerful voice in modern storytelling and a champion for positive change.



DR. LAUREL PEARSON

Laurel Pearson is an associate teaching professor in the Department of Anthropology at Penn State, she is also a member of the Liberal Arts Sustainability Council advisory committee. She received her BA in anthropology from Louisiana State University and PhD in genetics from Penn State. Her research interests include human variation, health disparities and her work centers greatly around anthropology and the holistic qualities of a liberal arts education to discuss our role in building a sustainable future. She lives in the village of Pine Grove Mills with her husband, daughter, two cats, a dog, and a few chickens where she enjoys gardening and cooking.





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SPECIAL THANKS

WPSU

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